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India's journey to the 2028 T20 World Cup in Australia and New Zealand began with a tough visit to Ireland, where it lost the two-match series 2-0 under new T20I captain Shreyas Iyer. What should have been an ideal warm-up ahead of July's five-match T20I series in England instead exposed the young Indian side's shortcomings, with Ireland outplaying it in every department across the two games.

It was the first series after India's T20 World Cup triumph. Suryakumar Yadav, who led the team to its second successive title and third overall, was stripped of the captaincy despite boasting an 84 per cent win percentage. **Shreyas, recalled to the format for the first time since 2023, was immediately handed the leadership following an impressive recent track record.**

His leadership credentials are well established, having captained Mumbai and IPL franchises Kolkata Knight Riders and Punjab Kings. Since 2024, Shreyas has won 36 of the 55 games he has captained, including title-winning campaigns with Mumbai in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (SMAT) and KKR in the IPL in 2024. In 2025, he also guided PBKS to the IPL final.

The Belfast series could have eased him into the role. Instead, India's first-ever series defeat to Ireland made for a far tougher start.

Despite the change in leadership, much of the attention centred on 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and his potential international debut. Despite India's batting struggles, the Gautam Gambhir-led management chose not to hand the prodigy his debut. The Ireland series would have been an ideal testing ground for the teenager.

India introduced

several fresh faces to its T20I setup, including Shreyas. He replaced Suryakumar, whose prolonged dip in form over the last 10 months, during which he managed 674 runs in 28 T20I innings and just 314 runs in IPL 2026, made it difficult for the Ajit Agarkar-led selection committee to

New star: If he plays against England, the 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi would break Sachin Tendulkar's record as the youngest man to play for India.

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persist with him any longer. The reshuffle, however, brought little immediate reward, with Shreyas scoring 3 and 10 across two innings at No. 4.

Another notable change saw Tilak Varma elevated to vice-captain ahead of the tour despite his underwhelming returns in the format. Batting at No. 5, Tilak's glaring issue with strike rotation through the middle overs once again came to the fore.

In the first game, he scored 19 off 21 balls in a chase of 183, while in the second, Tilak managed 55 off 46 balls chasing 154. Since 2025, Tilak has struck at 112.63 batting between overs 7 and 15. While he enjoys striking at over 151 against pace, he slows considerably against spin, managing a strike rate of 117.04.

While India has found high-intent batters at the top in Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson, Ishan Kishan and potentially Sooryavanshi, the middle order has struggled to sustain that tempo. Regardless of Tilak's form, identifying dependable lower-order batters will be one of India's biggest priorities over the next two years. Despite having played over 60 T20Is, the highly backed Washington Sundar has contributed little with either bat or ball, while Axar Patel's batting credentials have begun to decline.

The series also highlighted how crucial a fully fit Hardik Pandya is, both as a lower-order batter and as a bowler capable of delivering four quality overs.

But with both Pandya and his understudy Nitish Kumar Reddy unavailable, India handed a debut cap to Suryansh Shedge, another pace-bowling all-rounder. His stock has risen steadily over the past two years through impactful lower-order performances for Mumbai in the SMAT, strong displays for PBKS under Shreyas, and a recent stint with India A in Sri Lanka.

Shedge will be one to watch on this tour.

The upcoming five games will provide a stern test for Shreyas and the